


No. 1 · AUTUMN 2026 THE SCHOOL'S ESD NEWSLETTER OUT EVERY HALF-TERM

*"Progress marches on; it makes the great human journey..."* Victor Hugo, Les Misérables

**A newsletter to keep informed, get inspired and move forward together.**

**The SDGs** are the 17 Sustainable Development Goals the world has set itself for 2030 (see last page)



SDG 15 COVER STORY · BULGARIA

## Cinereous vultures return to the Rhodopes

Three pairs hatched chicks this spring, a first since 1993. A story of patience, science and European cooperation, just a few hours from Sofia. Read more on page 6 ›

Photo Artemy Voikhansky, CC BY-SA 4.0

## Editorial

Welcome aboard L'ODDysée d'Hugo! The title blends the Odyssey, that long voyage full of ports of call, with the 17 Sustainable Development Goals the world has set itself for 2030. Our namesake gives us our bearings, since for him progress is a great journey that humanity makes together.

This newsletter aims to inform us, inspire us and make us want to act. It shows what is moving forward at school, in Bulgaria, in France and worldwide, because we move faster when we know it is possible.

No journey is made alone. Students, families, teachers, student life, staff and leadership, everyone has a place on board. This first issue comes from the ESD team, the next ones will be written by our eco-delegates.

*Eric, Greg and Julie, ESD coordinators*

## In this issue

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SCHOOL LIFE

# At the LVH, we're moving forward!

*Back-to-school highlights and the SDG projects our students are running now*



SDG 3 16 SEPTEMBER

### The LVH on the move

Football, handball, table tennis and badminton for National School Sports Day, in a spirit of cooperation and sharing.



SDG 16 28 SEPT. TO 2 OCT.

### Democracy Week

Delegate elections across secondary. For 6th graders, a first vote in a booth, personal, free and secret.



SDG 16 SDG 17 27 TO 30 SEPT.

### Two students at the Nicosia Inter-CVL

With student reps from other schools, they explored engagement and student representation, and now share the experience with the CVL.

## Our SDG projects

SDG 12 — ONGOING

*Biology, the whole school community*

### Recycling paper, cardboard, batteries and caps

Middle school eco-delegates and eco-volunteers run the collection points with partner Ecobulpack and measure the amounts recycled.

SDG 11 — ONGOING

*Economics, Grade 10 A and B*

### A cycle lane for Sofia

After an escape game about a stolen bike, students are writing to city services to ask for a cycle lane.

SDG 4 — ONGOING

*History-Geography, Civics, Geopolitics and Economics*

### An international day to open every lesson

Each lesson opens with an international day, such as peace, anti-trafficking or access to information, to spark discussion.

SDG 13 — COMPLETED

*Economics, Grade 10 A and B*

### Climate and scarce resources

Students work with data on growth and emissions and learn to tell correlation from causation.

SCHOOL LIFE

# At the LVH, we're moving forward!

*Our SDG projects, continued*

SDG 5

COMPLETED

*History and Civics, Grade 11 A and B*

## Women in revolutions

Each student made a poster about a woman who fought for rights or peace, from Olympe de Gouges to Leymah Gbowee, for an exhibition at school.

SDG 16

COMPLETED

*Geopolitics and Political Science, Grade 11 specialty*

## An Athenian debate on democracy

Sides and jury drawn by lot, as in Athens. Facing ecological crises, do we need authoritarian power or a reinvented democracy?

SDG 16

COMPLETED

*Civics, Grade 8 A and C, Grade 11 A and B, 2 October*

## A day for non-violence

Awareness posters on the doors of every floor, and anonymous good-luck notes handed out to students and staff at break time.

SDG 16

COMPLETED

*Civics, Grade 11 A and B, 16 October*

## Preventing radicalisation, rejecting violence

In tribute to Samuel Paty and Dominique Bernard, four committees studied a fictional case and proposed prevention measures, at school, in sport and culture, and through the law.

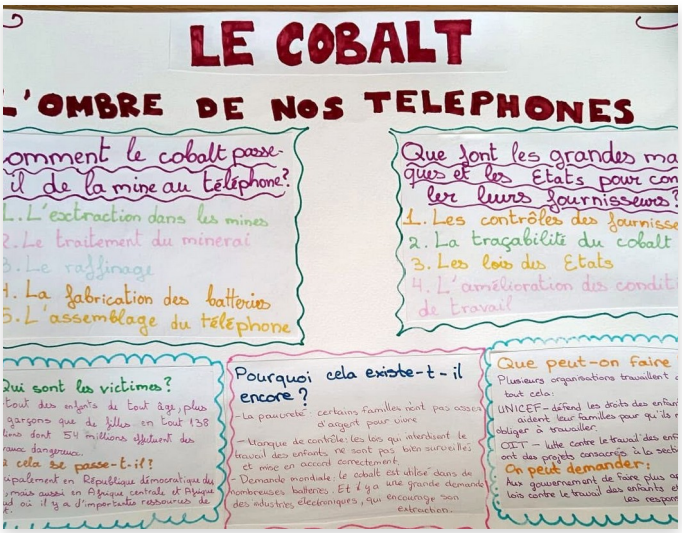
SDG 8

ONGOING

*History and Civics, Grade 8 A and C*

## Operation Broken Chains

Sent on a mission by an imaginary NGO, the Victor Hugo Organisation against Modern Slavery, students investigated Uzbek cotton, child soldiers, Haiti's restavèk children and the cobalt in our phones. Their findings became advocacy posters.



SCHOOL LIFE

# At the LVH, we're moving forward!

*From nursery to 12th grade, the whole school is moving forward*




SDG 15 SDG 4 *Grade 5, Vitosha Nature Park*

## 5th graders learn to read the mountain

On their first hike, a loop through the heart of the nature park, students learned to read a map and its key, find their way with a compass and estimate distances using the scale. They even measured the height of a tree with the lumberjack's cross. Learning outdoors means getting to know the nature around us, and so learning to protect it.




SDG 11 SDG 3 *Grade 9 classes, 13 October*

## National Resilience Day

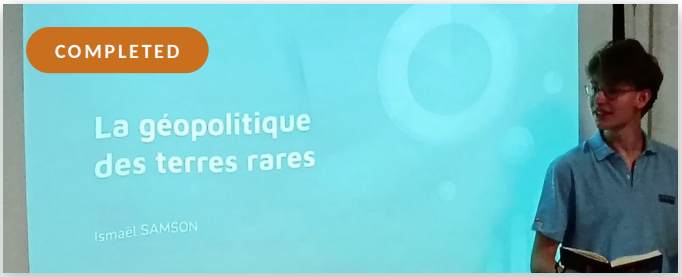
Natural and technological hazards, emergencies, life-saving skills. With our trainer teachers, 9th graders learned the right reflexes to protect themselves and others. Being prepared already makes us stronger together.




SDG 15 SDG 4 *Grade 2 A, science*

## Observing and classifying nature

Mineral, plant or animal? Pine cones, pebbles and leaves in hand, our 2nd graders in CE1 A are learning to observe, question and classify the world around them. All year long, they will explore the materials of their environment. Science starts with curiosity!




SDG 12 SDG 8 *Geopolitics, Grade 11*

## The geopolitics of everyday objects

Rare earths, T-shirts, trainers, phones. Each student gave a talk on the hidden issues behind an everyday object, from subsidised cotton to garment workshops and the unequal sharing of value. A way to shop with eyes wide open.




SDG 16 SDG 17 *September, elected students*

## MPs meet our student representatives

A delegation of MPs from the France-Bulgaria friendship groups met the school leadership, parent and staff representatives, and elected students. Listening to everyone and representing them in decisions is the heart of SDG 16.

NEWS

# In France

*Record heat and rising solar power, a back-to-school season all about energy*



Photo Florian Pépellin, CC BY-SA 4.0

SDG 13 SDG 6 CLIMATE

## A scorching September

According to Météo-France, September 2026 was the second hottest since 1900, after 2023, at 3.1 °C above normal. On 6 September, Lavaur, in the Tarn, recorded 40.3 °C, a national record for September.
Rainfall was about 70% below normal. Low rivers, cracked soil and thirsty forests, drought took hold across much of the country.

Read the source ›



Photo Jérémy-Günther-Heinz Jähnick, CC BY-SA 3.0

SDG 7 SDG 13 ENERGY

## French solar passes 34 gigawatts

By the end of June 2026, France had a record 34 GW of solar panels installed. In the second quarter they produced 14.1 TWh, or 8.6% of the electricity consumed. Installed capacity has more than tripled in five years.
The flip side is that the energy plan published in February lowers the 2030 target to 48 GW, and the grid must learn to store the power that floods in during sunny hours.

Read the source ›

**40.3 °C**
September record in Lavaur, on 6 September

**+3.1 °C**
above normal over the month

**34 GW**
of solar installed by end of June 2026

**In class** Compare the role of nuclear and solar power in the French and Bulgarian electricity mixes (pages 5 and 6). Two countries, two energy stories, one climate challenge.

NEWS

# In Bulgaria

*Sun, vultures and a pedestrian boulevard, sustainable news from our host country*

SDG 7 SDG 9 ENERGY

## When Bulgarian sunshine outstrips demand

On 8 October, solar plants produced nearly 4,300 MW, more than the country's entire demand at that moment. Large batteries store the midday surplus for the evening. As a result, net electricity exports jumped 62% in a year.

Read the source ›

### 8 October, at noon

Solar output




National demand




**+62 %**
net exports in one year

**× 9**
electricity delivered by batteries



Photo Charles J. Sharp, CC BY-SA 4.0

SDG 15 BIODIVERSITY

## Cinereous vultures return to the Rhodopes

This spring, three pairs hatched chicks in the Eastern Rhodopes, a first since 1993. Since 2022, the Bulgarian Society for the Protection of Birds and its partners have released 40 birds from Spain and built artificial nests.

Read the source ›



Photo MrPanyGoff, CC BY-SA 3.0

SDG 11 SDG 3 CITY

## Sofia opens Tsar Osvoboditel Boulevard to pedestrians

This summer, the city closed the boulevard to cars every weekend in August. A mobile station measured a 6.6% drop in traffic pollution from the very first weekend.

Read the source ›

**The Bulgarian word** **черен лешояд** (cheren leshoyad), the cinereous vulture, literally the black vulture.

NEWS

# Around the world

*Two major meetings for climate and biodiversity this autumn*



Photo REHBER0770, CC BY-SA 4.0

SDG 13 SDG 14 SDG 17 COP31

## Next stop Antalya for COP31

From 9 to 20 November, the world climate conference takes place in Antalya, in Türkiye, Bulgaria's neighbour. In a first, two countries are sharing the roles. Türkiye hosts and presides over the conference, while Australia leads the negotiations. Roadmaps are expected on ocean protection and the gradual phase-out of fossil fuels.

Read the source ›

KEY FIGURE

**36 %**

of SDG targets are on track or making moderate progress, according to the UN's 2026 report.

Yet there is progress. 92% of humanity has access to electricity, internet access has risen from 40% to 74% since 2015, and nearly a billion people have gained access to safe drinking water.

Read the report ›



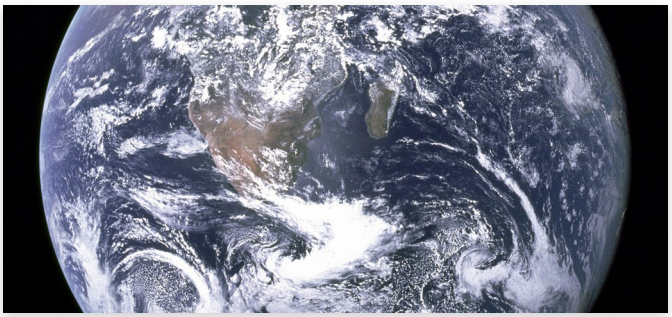
Photo Serouj Ourishian, CC BY-SA 3.0

SDG 15 SDG 14 BIODIVERSITY

## Biodiversity COP17, taking stock

From 19 to 30 October, Yerevan, Armenia, hosts COP17 on biodiversity. It is the first review of the 2022 agreement, which aims to protect 30% of land and oceans by 2030. A draft report finds countries are off track on 22 of the 23 targets.

Read the source ›



SDG 13 CLIMATE

## Second-hottest September

According to the European Copernicus service, September 2026 ranks second worldwide after 2023, 1.63 °C above pre-industrial levels. Average sea surface temperature set a record for September.

Read the source ›

GOOD NEWS

# What's going well

*Good news from the planet, because there is plenty of it*



Photo Dominik Keller, CC BY-SA 3.0

SDG 14 SDG 15 NATURE

## Nature bounces back faster than we think

The WWF's Living Planet Report 2026 recalls that monitored wildlife populations have fallen by 73% on average since 1970. But it also highlights spectacular comebacks, by tigers, turtles, tuna and elephants, wherever protection measures have been taken.

Read the source ›



SDG 15 NEW ZEALAND

## The wētāpunga saved from extinction

The world's heaviest insect, as heavy as a mouse, is no longer threatened. Its status has moved to “increasing” after fifteen years of breeding and more than 11,000 insects released on ten predator-free islands.

Read the source ›

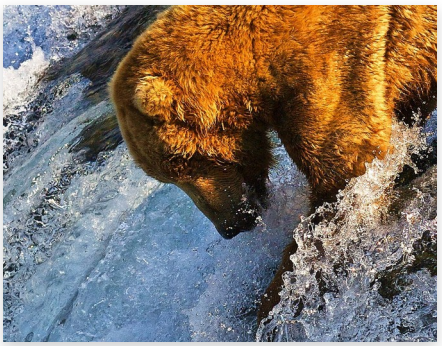


Photo Dmitry Azovtsev, CC BY-SA 3.0

SDG 15 ALASKA

## Backpack, Fat Bear Week champion

Every autumn, Katmai National Park elects its fattest bear before hibernation. Backpack won with 2.7 million votes. Behind the fun lies an ecology lesson, healthy rivers and forests feed the bears.

Read the source ›

## In brief



Photo Wayamo Foundation, CC BY-SA 2.0

SDG 16 PEACE

### Navi Pillay, 2026 Nobel Peace Prize

The former UN High Commissioner for Human Rights is honoured for her work for peace and international law.

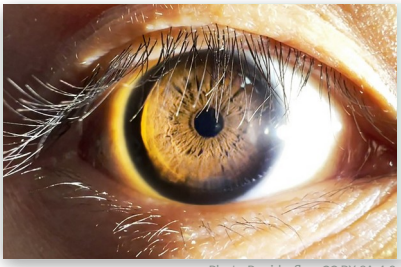


Photo Rapidreflex, CC BY-SA 4.0

SDG 3 HEALTH

### Gene therapy brings back light

Combined with special glasses, it restored light sensitivity to six out of ten patients with a severe retinal disease.

Source for these briefs ›

SOLUTIONS

# It works!

*Problems, solutions, measured results*




SDG 3 SDG 11 AIR

## London breathes easier

Since 2019, London has charged the most polluting vehicles to enter the centre. Imperial College researchers link this low emission zone to an 8.1% drop in emergency hospital admissions for cardiovascular disease and 6.2% for respiratory disease.

Read the source ›



Photo Oregon State University, CC BY-SA 2.0

SDG 6 SDG 14 SDG 15 RIVERS

## Without dams, salmon come back

On the Klamath River, between Oregon and California, four hydroelectric dams were removed, the last in 2024. The following year, the number of Chinook salmon swimming upriver to spawn rose by 72%.

Read the source ›



Photo tomline43, CC BY 2.0

SDG 15 SDG 13 FORESTS AND HEATHLAND

## Letting nature back in to fight wildfires

In the UK, a Rewilding Britain report shows that restored habitats burn less than monocultures. Of 285 rewilding projects over 40 hectares, only one was hit by fire this year.

Read the source ›



Photo Dicklyon, CC BY 4.0

SDG 13 SDG 16 CLIMATE JUSTICE

## Two retired teachers take on a coal mine

In Australia, the High Court dismissed the Mount Pleasant mine operator's appeal. Permission to expand the mine, ruled unlawful in 2025, will not be restored. Behind the case are Wendy Wales and Tony Lonergan, two retired teachers.

Read the source ›

**And at the LVH?** Our students also go from problem to solution, from recycling to the cycle lane requested from the city of Sofia (pages 2 to 4).

ACTING TOGETHER

# Save the date

*The big events of the autumn, a quiz and a challenge for everyone*

**19 to 30 Oct.**
Biodiversity COP17 in Yerevan

**9 to 20 Nov.**
Climate COP31 in Antalya

**11 and 12 Nov.**
Heads of State Summit at COP31

**1 Dec.**
World AIDS Day

## The quiz, true or false?

1. On 8 October, Bulgaria produced more solar electricity than it consumed.
2. The COP31 climate conference is in Brazil.
3. The wētāpunga is a New Zealand bird.
4. Cinereous vultures had not bred in the Eastern Rhodopes since 1993.
5. In London, the low emission zone is linked to fewer emergency hospital admissions.

*Answers. 1 true, page 6. 2 false, Antalya in Türkiye, page 7. 3 false, it's an insect, page 8. 4 true, page 6. 5 true, page 9.*

## The ODDysée challenge

During the autumn holidays, pick up a tree leaf in Bulgaria, in town or in the mountains, and try to identify its species. Show it to the eco-delegates of your year group, who are preparing the next issue. The best ones will be featured!



CULTURE

# Hugo's corner!




*A text by Victor HUGO, then our favourite picks to read, watch and listen to*

## Sowing Season. Evening

SDG 2 SDG 12 SDG 15

*Victor Hugo, Songs of the Streets and Woods, 1865*

*It is the hour of twilight.*
*Beneath a gateway, I admire*
*The fading day that lights*
*The final hour of labour.*

*In the fields, bathed in night,*
*I gaze, moved, upon the rags*
*Of an old man who casts by handfuls*
*The harvest-to-be in the furrows.*

*His tall dark silhouette*
*Looms over the deep furrows.*
*One feels how deeply he must trust*
*In the useful flight of days.*

*He walks across the vast plain,*
*Comes, goes, flings the seed afar,*
*Opens his hand, and starts again,*
*And I muse, a hidden witness,*

*While, unfurling all its veils,*
*The dusk, where murmurs blend,*
*Seems to stretch up to the stars*
*The sower's majestic gesture.*

The old man is sowing a harvest he may never reap. Acting today for those who will come tomorrow is the very definition of sustainable development.

The original on Wikisource ›

## To read, watch and listen to

NOVEL

SDG 15 SDG 8

### Bûcheron

*Mathias Bonneau, Seuil*

Winner of the 2026 Ecology Novel Prize. Twelve seasons of logging in family forests, and an uncomfortable question. What becomes of our bond with the forest when we enter it with a chainsaw?

Find out more ›

FILM

SDG 15 SDG 11

### Hoppers

*Daniel Chong, Pixar, March 2026*

Mabel transfers her mind into a robot beaver and helps a beaver colony defend its habitat against a developer. Funny, inventive, one for the whole family.

View details ›

MUSIC

SDG 10 SDG 11

### Kafé Griyé

*Davy Sicard, February 2026*

The new album by the singer from Réunion. His music draws on maloya, born from the songs of enslaved people and inscribed on UNESCO's intangible heritage list in 2009. A voice for memory and living together.

Listen ›

**Debate in class** What about you? What are you sowing today for tomorrow's planet?

OUR COMPASS

# The 17 SDGs

*Adopted by the 193 UN member states in 2015, to be achieved by 2030*

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 No Poverty | 2 Zero Hunger | 3 Good Health and Well-being | 4 Quality Education | 5 Gender Equality | 6 Clean Water and Sanitation |
| 7 Affordable and Clean Energy | 8 Decent Work and Economic Growth | 9 Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure | 10 Reduced Inequalities | 11 Sustainable Cities and Communities | 12 Responsible Consumption and Production |
| 13 Climate Action | 14 Life Below Water | 15 Life on Land | 16 Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions | 17 Partnerships for the Goals | 2030 17 goals, one planet |

Discover the 17 SDGs on the UN website ›

## Next issue

Issue 2 will be out just before the winter holidays, and it will be produced by the eco-delegates.

## Got news to share?

gregory.cron2@aefe.fr

## Bring others along on the ODDysée!

Every action counts, and it counts double when it is shared. Talk about the SDGs around you, at home, in class, at work. Together, we will move forward faster.

**About**

L'ODDysée d'Hugo, newsletter of the ESD team, Lycée français Victor Hugo, Sofia.
Written by Grégory Cron.

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